where they are taught to solve the problems mechanically. In the formative years of their teens, they neither get any societal exposure nor build relationships of any kind, not even with their closest family members. In short, they have no internal mechanism for emotional support. In stress, they have no one to fall back on."

Nearly all the students who land up at the IITs are used to being toppers—in their schools and in the neighbourhood. When they come to the IITs, they find themselves in a crowd of toppers, where they are one among many and not necessarily the top of the pack.

Students at the IITs also come from different parts of the country, and their language, lifestyle, economic and education levels differ from each other. "Lots of students come with past baggage, which could range from family stress, financial liabilities to relationship issues. They don't share it with anyone because the environment within the IITs is not conducive to sharing," says Dr Harish Shetty, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist. Many come from vernacular medium schools and find it difficult to grasp tough concepts as the medium of instruction is mostly English. They start clocking poor grades, have high backlogs and fear that they will not live up to the high hopes everyone places on them. "Here, we are in a continuously competitive world," says Paridhi Baruah, a second-year B.Tech. student at IIT Guwahati. "It's not possible to perform all the time." Complexes start building up and, sadly, go unnoticed most of the time.

As in the case of Vaipu Pushpak Sreesai, a third-year B.Tech. student of IIT Madras, who died by suicide on March 14. He had stopped socialising with his friends since he started getting backlogs in his semesters. A native of Kadapa in Andhra Pradesh, Sreesai did not get any institutional support, claim his friends. However, even institutional support and treatment were not enough for Hari Prasath, a third-year B.Tech. student at IIT Delhi who ended his life in his hostel room in June 2021. He was doing well until the second year at the institute, but started struggling with his studies after that and went into depression. While he was undergoing treatment, his friends in a statement flagged the language barrier and cultural isolation among the reasons behind students' suicide. "His attendance was zero. He was failing in almost all subjects. He showed all signs of taking an extreme step, yet nobody paid much attention. Such is the mechanical world of the IITs," says one of his friends.

GRIM TALLY

IITs across the country are reporting frequent cases of suicides by students

IIT MADRAS

↘ **Apr. 21, 2023:** Kedar Suresh Chougule, a second-year Chemical Engineering student from Maharashtra, is found hanging in his hostel room

↘ **Mar. 14:** Vaipu Pushpak Sreesai, a third-year Electrical Engineering student from Andhra Pradesh, is discovered dead in his room

↘ **Feb. 13:** Stephen Sunny, a second-year research scholar from Maharashtra, is found dead in his hostel room



JAISON G

WHAT AILS IITs The entrance of IIT Madras in Chennai

IIT BOMBAY



↘ **Feb. 12, 2023:** Darshan Solanki, a first-year student of the B.Tech. (Chemical) course from Ahmedabad, dies after jumping off the seventh floor of the hostel building. Later, his batchmate Arman Khatri is arrested on the charge of abetment to suicide

↘ **Jan. 17, 2022:** Darshan Malviya, a post-graduate student from Madhya Pradesh, ends his life by jumping off the terrace of his hostel

IIT GUWAHATI

↘ **Jan. 9, 2023:** Hrithik Bhavani, a B.Tech. final-year student from Nagpur, is found dead in his room under mysterious circumstances



"HAPPINESS IS A **COLLECTIVE RESPONSIBILITY. OUR WELLNESS SURVEY** IS A STEP TO ENSURE THAT ON THE CAMPUS"

V. KAMAKOTI *Director, IIT Madras*